

Model Uncertainty in Cross-Country Growth Regressions

Fernández, Ley & Steel (2001, *J. Applied Econometrics*) — Reproduction and ML extension
(Day 3: Regularization & Variable Selection)

Intro-ML teaching tutorial

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Contents

1	The study and why it anchors a variable-selection lesson	1
2	Descriptive analysis	2
2.1	Dataset, provenance and unit of analysis	2
2.2	The outcome in depth: average GDP-per-capita growth, 1960–1992	4
2.3	Univariate distributions of the predictors	6
2.4	Missing-data analysis	9
2.5	Bivariate relationships with growth	10
2.6	Multivariate structure and collinearity	12
3	Reproduction gate 1 — the data are the published data	15
4	Reproduce the published main result: BMA posterior inclusion probabilities	16
5	The OLS that motivates everything	17
6	Standardization — why and how	17
7	Ridge, lasso and elastic net via glmnet	18
7.1	Coefficient paths	18
7.2	Cross-validation to choose λ (<code>lambda.min</code> and <code>lambda.1se</code>)	19
7.3	Feature importance from standardized coefficients	20
8	Best-subset selection with abess, contrasted with lasso	20
9	Hyperparameter tuning: λ and α together	22
10	Out-of-sample comparison: does regularization actually help?	23
11	Takeaway	24

1 The study and why it anchors a variable-selection lesson

Citation. Carmen Fernández, Eduardo Ley & Mark F. J. Steel (2001), “Model uncertainty in cross-country growth regressions,” *Journal of Applied Econometrics* **16**(5): 563–576. Data archive: <http://qed.econ.queensu.ca/jae/2001-v16.5/fernandez-ley-steel/> (also shipped, identically, in the R package **BMS** as `datafls`).

The economic problem. Empirical growth economics asks: *which* national characteristics explain why some countries grew faster than others between 1960 and 1992? Dozens of candidate determinants have been proposed — initial GDP, schooling, life expectancy, religion shares, institutions, geography, trade openness, investment. Fernández, Ley & Steel assemble **41 candidate regressors for 72 countries** and confront the central difficulty head-on: with so many correlated predictors and so few observations, *no single regression is credible*. Their answer is Bayesian Model Averaging (BMA) — average over all $2^{41} \approx 2.2 \times 10^{12}$ possible models, weighting each by its posterior probability, and report each variable’s **posterior inclusion probability (PIP)**: the probability that its coefficient is non-zero.

This is *exactly* the Day-3 problem — many correlated predictors, standardization, and formal variable selection — dressed in 2001 Bayesian clothing. We first **reproduce their headline result exactly**, then show what the modern regularization toolkit (ridge / lasso / elastic net / best-subset) adds and how its selections line up with their BMA verdict.

```
library(BMS)           # ships the exact FLS 2001 data as datafls; provides bms()
d <- read.csv(paste0(
  "https://raw.githubusercontent.com/bdesmarais/intro",
  "-ml-statistical-horizons-4day/main/tutorials/day3_",
  "regularization_and_selection/fernandez_ley_steel_g",
  "rowth/data/fls_growth.csv")) # a verbatim copy of BMS::datafls
y <- d$y                # growth of real GDP per capita, 1960-1992
X <- as.matrix(d[, -1]) # the 41 candidate determinants
p <- ncol(X); n <- nrow(X)
c(countries = n, predictors = p)
```

```
## countries predictors
##           72           41
```

The outcome y is average annual growth of real per-capita GDP, 1960–1992 (Penn World Table). Its mean is about 2.1% with s.d. 1.8%.

2 Descriptive analysis

Before any modeling we meet the data properly. Good exploratory work is not a formality here: with **41 candidate predictors over only 72 countries**, the descriptive picture — how the outcome is shaped, which predictors carry signal, and above all how tightly the predictors are entangled with one another — *is* the argument for the model-averaging and regularization machinery that follows. This section is deliberately thorough.

2.1 Dataset, provenance and unit of analysis

The **unit of analysis is a country**. The file `fls_growth.csv` is a verbatim copy of `BMS::datafls`, itself the exact dataset archived with Fernández, Ley & Steel (2001) at the *Journal of Applied Econometrics* data archive. There are **72 countries** and **42 columns** — the growth outcome plus **41 candidate determinants**. Each row is a single cross-section: every variable is either an *initial-year* value (e.g. 1960 income, GDP60) or a *period average / summary* over the 1960–1992 growth window. There is therefore **no time dimension to exploit** — this is one long, wide cross-section, not a panel. The 72 countries are those for which the full battery of 41 regressors was available; the sample is not a random draw but the intersection of several source datasets (Penn World Table, Barro–Lee, Sala-i-Martin’s compilations), which is itself a mild selection caveat worth remembering when generalizing.

```
# classify each predictor as 0/1 binary vs continuous
pred <- d[, -1] # drop the outcome column
is_binary <- sapply(pred, function(x) all(x %in% c(0, 1)))
bin_vars <- names(is_binary)[is_binary] # 0/1 dummies
num_vars <- names(is_binary)[!is_binary] # continuous / count
```

```
data.frame(kind = c("continuous", "binary (0/1)", "total predictors"),
           count = c(length(num_vars), length(bin_vars), ncol(pred)))
```

```
##           kind count
## 1    continuous   34
## 2    binary (0/1)    7
## 3 total predictors   41
```

So of the 41 regressors, **34 are continuous** (incomes, enrolment shares, life expectancy, geography, investment ratios, ...) and **7 are 0/1 indicators** (colonial heritage, region, war, trade orientation). A compact **variable dictionary** for the outcome and a representative slice of the modeling predictors:

```
dict <- read.csv(text = "
variable,type,description
y,continuous,(outcome),Avg annual growth of real GDP per capita 1960-1992
GDP60,continuous,Log real GDP per capita in 1960 (initial income)
LifeExp,continuous,Life expectancy at birth (years) circa 1960
EquipInv,continuous,Equipment investment share of GDP
NequipInv,continuous,Non-equipment investment share of GDP
PrScEnroll,continuous,Primary-school enrolment rate 1960
HighEnroll,continuous,Higher-education enrolment rate
RuleofLaw,continuous,Rule-of-law index (0-1)
YrsOpen,continuous,Fraction of years economy open to trade
Age,continuous,Age of national state / years since independence
Abslat,continuous,Absolute latitude of the country
Area,continuous,Land area
Popg,continuous,Population growth rate
Confucian,continuous,Fraction of population Confucian
Muslim,continuous,Fraction of population Muslim
Protestants,continuous,Fraction of population Protestant
SubSahara,binary,=1 if Sub-Saharan Africa
LatAmerica,binary,=1 if Latin America
Spanish,binary,=1 former Spanish colony
French,binary,=1 former French colony
Brit,binary,=1 former British colony
WarDummy,binary,=1 country took part in a war 1960-1990
OutwarOr,binary,=1 outward-oriented trade regime
", strip.white = TRUE)
knitr::kable(dict, caption = "Variable dictionary (outcome + a representative subset
↪ the 41 predictors). Continuous shares are proportions in [0,1] unless noted.")
```

Table 1: Variable dictionary (outcome + a representative subset of the 41 predictors). Continuous shares are proportions in [0,1] unless noted.

variable	type	description
y	continuous (outcome)	Avg annual growth of real GDP per capita 1960-1992
GDP60	continuous	Log real GDP per capita in 1960 (initial income)
LifeExp	continuous	Life expectancy at birth (years) circa 1960
EquipInv	continuous	Equipment investment share of GDP
NequipInv	continuous	Non-equipment investment share of GDP
PrScEnroll	continuous	Primary-school enrolment rate 1960
HighEnroll	continuous	Higher-education enrolment rate
RuleofLaw	continuous	Rule-of-law index (0-1)

variable	type	description
YrsOpen	continuous	Fraction of years economy open to trade
Age	continuous	Age of national state / years since independence
Abslat	continuous	Absolute latitude of the country
Area	continuous	Land area
Popg	continuous	Population growth rate
Confucian	continuous	Fraction of population Confucian
Muslim	continuous	Fraction of population Muslim
Protestants	continuous	Fraction of population Protestant
SubSahara	binary	=1 if Sub-Saharan Africa
LatAmerica	binary	=1 if Latin America
Spanish	binary	=1 former Spanish colony
French	binary	=1 former French colony
Brit	binary	=1 former British colony
WarDummy	binary	=1 country took part in a war 1960-1990
OutwarOr	binary	=1 outward-oriented trade regime

The full set of 41 predictors is profiled in the summary table further below; the dictionary lists the outcome plus the highest-salience determinants and one example of each dummy family.

2.2 The outcome in depth: average GDP-per-capita growth, 1960–1992

```
library(ggplot2)
ggplot(data.frame(y = d$y), aes(x = y)) +
  geom_histogram(aes(y = after_stat(density)), bins = 18,
                 fill = "steelblue", colour = "white", alpha = 0.85) +
  geom_density(colour = "firebrick", linewidth = 0.8) +
  geom_vline(xintercept = mean(d$y), linetype = 2) +
  geom_vline(xintercept = median(d$y), linetype = 3) +
  labs(x = "average annual growth, 1960-1992", y = "density") +
  theme_minimal(base_size = 11)
```

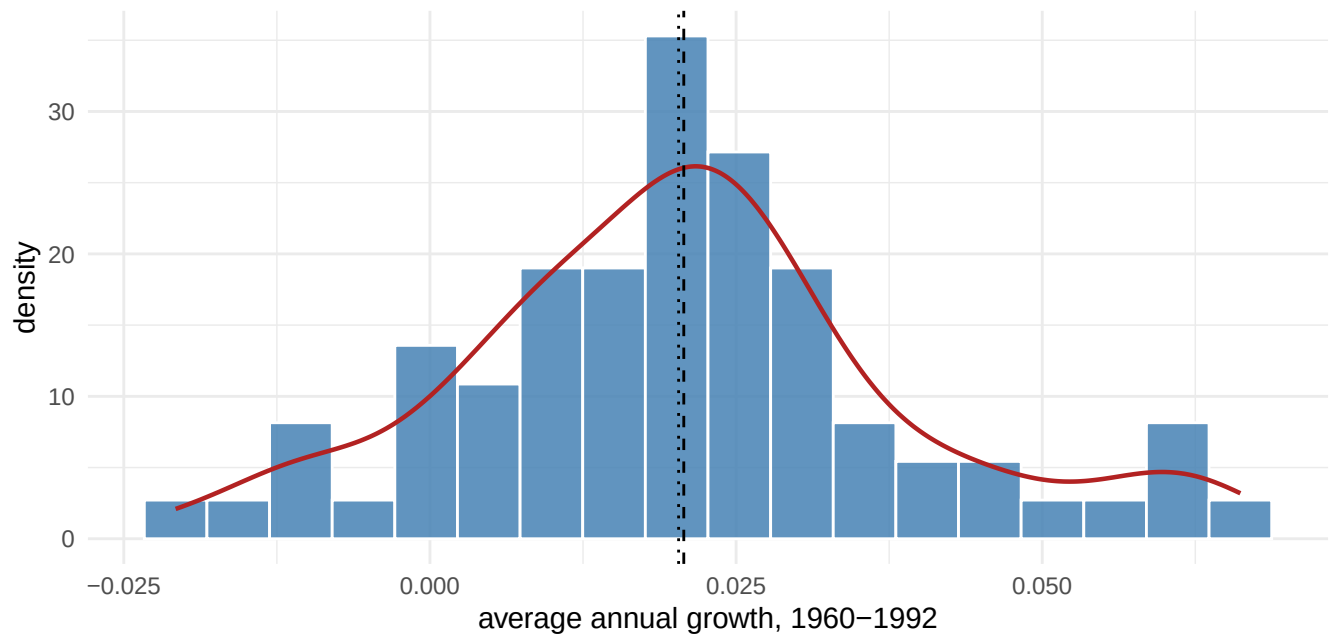


Figure 1: Distribution of average annual growth of real GDP per capita, 1960–1992, across 72 countries. Solid red = kernel density; dashed = mean; dotted = median. The distribution is close to symmetric with a mild right lean and no extreme outliers.

A full numeric profile of the outcome, including shape diagnostics from **e1071** (skewness and excess kurtosis):

```
library(e1071)
q <- quantile(d$y)
out_stats <- data.frame(
  statistic = c("n", "mean", "sd", "min", "Q1", "median", "Q3", "max",
    "IQR", "skewness", "kurtosis (excess)"),
  value = round(c(length(d$y), mean(d$y), sd(d$y), min(d$y),
    q[2], median(d$y), q[4], max(d$y), IQR(d$y),
    skewness(d$y), kurtosis(d$y)), 4))
knitr::kable(out_stats, row.names = FALSE,
  caption = "Full summary of the outcome (annual GDP-per-capita growth rate).")
```

Table 2: Full summary of the outcome (annual GDP-per-capita growth rate).

statistic	value
n	72.0000
mean	0.0207
sd	0.0183
min	-0.0208
Q1	0.0094
median	0.0203
Q3	0.0287
max	0.0662
IQR	0.0193
skewness	0.3179
kurtosis (excess)	0.1538

Growth ranges from about -2% (a handful of countries that *shrank* over three decades) to roughly $+7\%$ per year, centred near $+2\%$. The mean and median sit almost on top of each other, the skewness is small and positive (0.32) and the excess kurtosis is near zero (0.15) — i.e. the distribution is close to Gaussian, with the right tail a touch heavier than the left because a few East-Asian “miracle” economies grew exceptionally fast. There is **no floor, ceiling, or zero-inflation**, and no observation is an obvious outlier. A log or Box–Cox transform of the outcome is therefore **not warranted**; growth enters the models on its natural scale, which also keeps the reproduction faithful to FLS.

2.3 Univariate distributions of the predictors

For the continuous predictors, a faceted grid of histograms shows the spread of scales and shapes at a glance — from tightly bounded $[0,1]$ shares to heavy-tailed area and income variables. We show a representative dozen (the highest-salience determinants plus a couple of skewed geographic ones):

```
library(dplyr)
show_num <- c("GDP60", "LifeExp", "EquipInv", "NequipInv", "PrScEnroll",
              "HighEnroll", "RuleofLaw", "YrsOpen", "Age", "Abslat",
              "Popg", "Area")
long <- do.call(rbind, lapply(show_num, function(v)
  data.frame(variable = v, value = d[[v]])))
ggplot(long, aes(value)) +
  geom_histogram(bins = 15, fill = "steelblue", colour = "white") +
  facet_wrap(~ variable, scales = "free", ncol = 4) +
  labs(x = NULL, y = "count") +
  theme_minimal(base_size = 9)
```

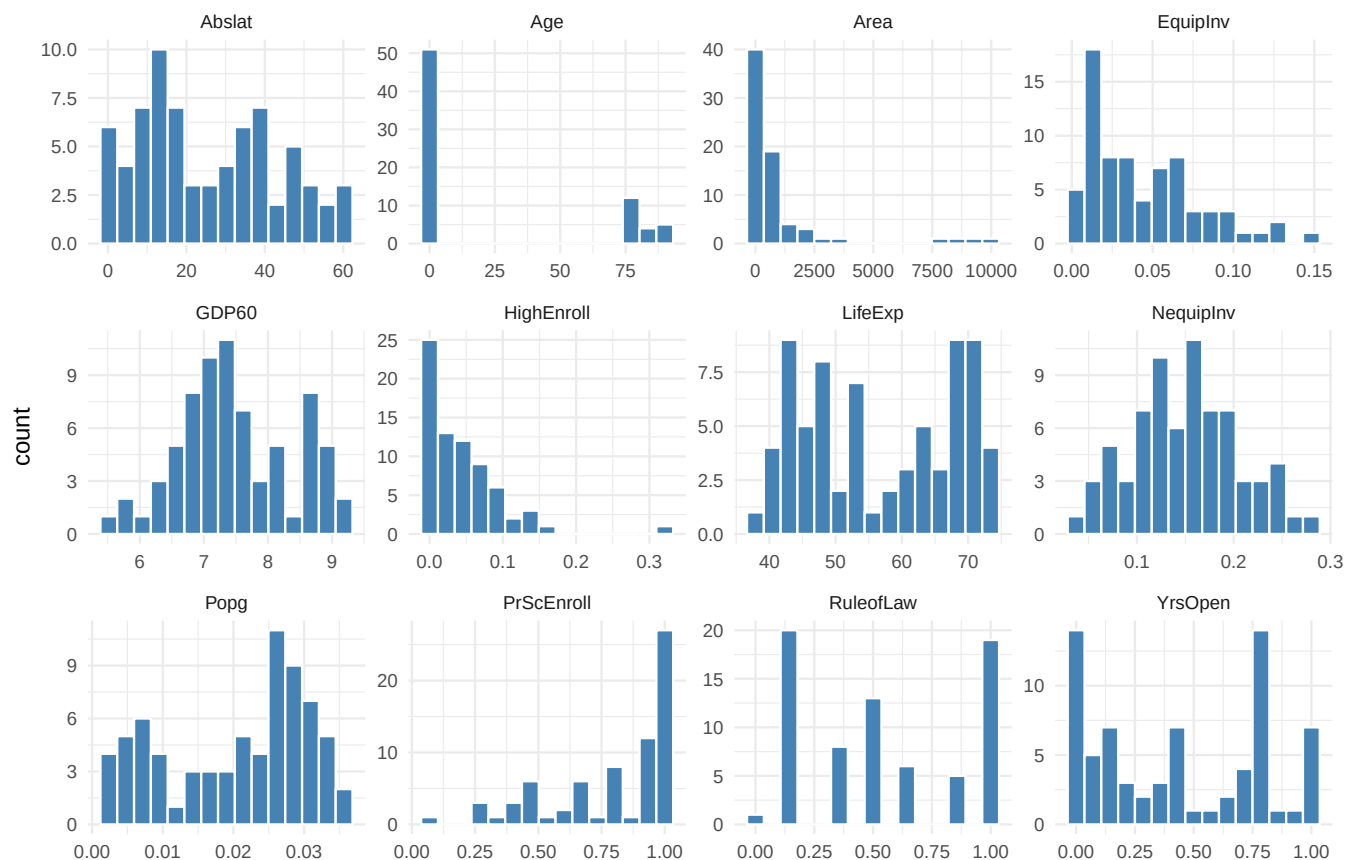


Figure 2: Univariate distributions of twelve representative continuous predictors. Note the mix of near-symmetric variables (GDP60, LifeExp) and strongly skewed / bounded ones (Area, EquipInv, PrScEnroll), which is why penalized methods standardize before fitting.

A full summary-statistics table for **ALL 34** continuous predictors (rounded; skew from e1071) — so nothing is hidden even though we only plot a subset:

```
num_summary <- data.frame(
  variable = num_vars,
  n        = sapply(num_vars, function(v) sum(!is.na(d[[v]]))),
  n_miss   = sapply(num_vars, function(v) sum(is.na(d[[v]]))),
  mean     = round(sapply(num_vars, function(v) mean(d[[v]])), 3),
  sd       = round(sapply(num_vars, function(v) sd(d[[v]])), 3),
  min      = round(sapply(num_vars, function(v) min(d[[v]])), 3),
  median   = round(sapply(num_vars, function(v) median(d[[v]])), 3),
  max      = round(sapply(num_vars, function(v) max(d[[v]])), 3),
  skew     = round(sapply(num_vars, function(v) e1071::skewness(d[[v]])), 2),
  row.names = NULL)
knitr::kable(num_summary, row.names = FALSE,
  caption = "Summary statistics for all 34 continuous predictors (n, missing, mean, sd,
  ↪ min, median, max, skew). Scales differ by orders of magnitude, foreshadowing the
  ↪ need to standardize.")
```

Table 3: Summary statistics for all 34 continuous predictors (n, missing, mean, sd, min, median, max, skew). Scales differ by orders of magnitude, foreshadowing the need to standardize.

variable	n	n_miss	mean	sd	min	median	max	skew
Abslat	72	0	25.733	17.250	0.228	22.120	60.212	0.31
Area	72	0	972.917	2051.976	1.000	312.500	9976.000	3.30
PrScEnroll	72	0	0.795	0.246	0.070	0.945	1.000	-1.00
LifeExp	72	0	56.581	11.448	37.900	54.600	73.400	0.00
GDP60	72	0	7.492	0.885	5.518	7.388	9.188	0.14
Mining	72	0	0.045	0.077	0.000	0.018	0.533	3.95
EcoOrg	72	0	3.542	1.266	0.000	3.000	5.000	-0.87
YrsOpen	72	0	0.439	0.355	0.000	0.411	1.000	0.15
Age	72	0	23.708	37.307	0.000	0.000	90.000	0.92
Buddha	72	0	0.056	0.184	0.000	0.000	0.950	3.57
Catholic	72	0	0.422	0.397	0.000	0.270	1.000	0.31
Confucian	72	0	0.019	0.087	0.000	0.000	0.600	5.09
EthnoL	72	0	0.371	0.296	0.000	0.315	0.930	0.36
Hindu	72	0	0.018	0.101	0.000	0.000	0.830	7.23
Jewish	72	0	0.013	0.097	0.000	0.000	0.820	8.11
Muslim	72	0	0.148	0.295	0.000	0.000	1.000	2.10
PrExports	72	0	0.673	0.299	0.041	0.804	0.998	-0.67
Protestants	72	0	0.173	0.252	0.000	0.050	0.950	1.78
RuleofLaw	72	0	0.551	0.335	0.000	0.500	1.000	0.17
Popg	72	0	0.020	0.010	0.002	0.024	0.036	-0.45
WorkPop	72	0	-0.954	0.189	-1.351	-0.939	-0.597	-0.12
LabForce	72	0	9305.376	24906.056	210.918	2898.396	195781.500	6.10
HighEnroll	72	0	0.043	0.052	0.000	0.026	0.321	2.46
PublEdupect	72	0	0.025	0.009	0.004	0.023	0.046	0.22
RevnCoup	72	0	0.182	0.238	0.000	0.080	1.190	1.84
PolRights	72	0	3.451	1.896	1.000	3.694	6.667	0.06
CivLib	72	0	3.466	1.712	1.000	3.667	6.611	-0.04
English	72	0	0.076	0.239	0.000	0.000	0.974	3.03
Foreign	72	0	0.374	0.422	0.000	0.055	1.004	0.41
RFEXDist	72	0	121.708	41.001	51.000	112.500	277.000	1.55
EquipInv	72	0	0.044	0.035	0.003	0.036	0.148	0.95
NequipInv	72	0	0.149	0.055	0.037	0.152	0.280	0.12
stdBMP	72	0	45.596	95.802	0.001	13.149	588.627	3.52
BlMktPm	72	0	0.157	0.291	0.000	0.028	1.855	3.36

The table makes the scaling problem concrete: **Area** and **RFEXDist** run into the thousands while enrolment and religion shares live in [0,1]. Left unstandardized, a single penalty would punish the large-scale variables far more than the shares — which is exactly why every penalized fit below standardizes first.

For the **7 binary indicators**, base rates (the share of countries coded 1) are far more informative than a mean/sd, and a bar chart makes the class balance immediate:

```
bin_tab <- data.frame(
  dummy      = bin_vars,
  n_ones     = sapply(bin_vars, function(v) sum(d[[v]] == 1)),
  proportion = round(sapply(bin_vars, function(v) mean(d[[v]])), 3))
bin_tab <- bin_tab[order(-bin_tab$proportion), ]
knitr::kable(bin_tab, row.names = FALSE,
  caption = "Binary (0/1) indicators, with the share of countries coded 1.")
```

Table 4: Binary (0/1) indicators, with the share of countries coded 1.

dummy	n_ones	proportion
WarDummy	29	0.403
OutwarOr	28	0.389
Brit	23	0.319
LatAmerica	20	0.278
Spanish	16	0.222
SubSahara	15	0.208
French	9	0.125

```
ggplot(bin_tab, aes(x = reorder(dummy, proportion), y = proportion)) +
  geom_col(fill = "steelblue") +
  coord_flip() +
  labs(x = NULL, y = "share of countries = 1") +
  theme_minimal(base_size = 10)
```

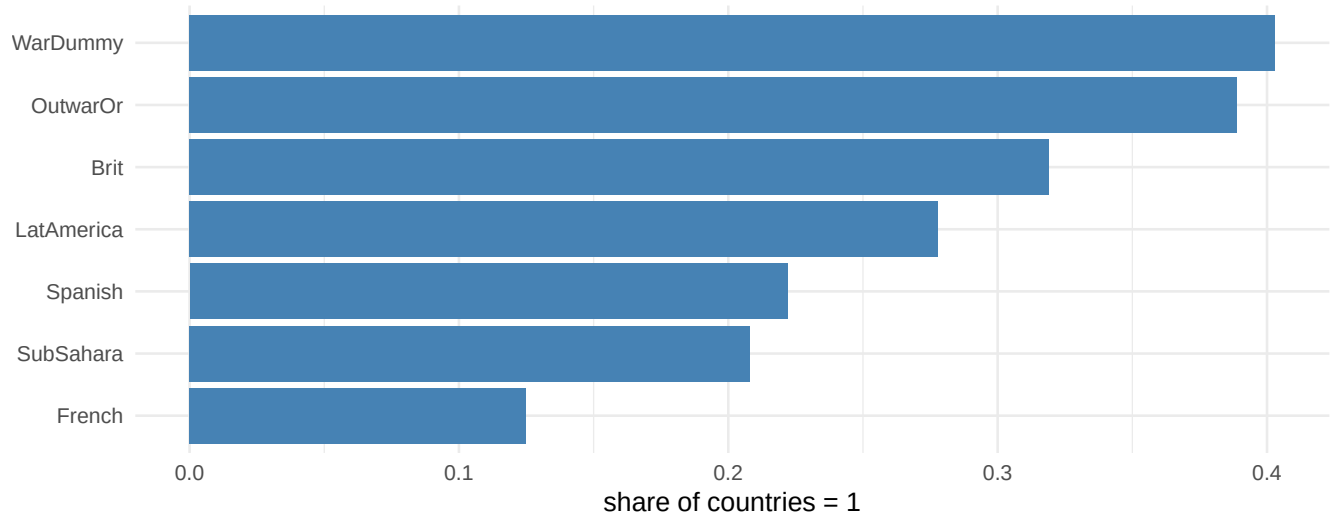


Figure 3: Base rates of the seven 0/1 indicator predictors. Several are quite rare (e.g. outward-orientation), so their coefficients rest on few countries and are prime candidates for shrinkage.

Some dummies are rare — only a handful of countries carry a 1 — so any coefficient estimated for them leans on very little data, another reason the methods below prefer to shrink rather than trust raw OLS.

2.4 Missing-data analysis

```
miss_by_var <- colSums(is.na(d))
data.frame(
  metric = c("total missing cells", "variables with any NA",
            "complete rows", "rows total"),
  value = c(sum(is.na(d)), sum(miss_by_var > 0),
            sum(complete.cases(d)), nrow(d)))
```

```
##                metric value
## 1  total missing cells      0
## 2 variables with any NA      0
## 3      complete rows       72
## 4      rows total          72
```

The dataset is **fully complete**: zero missing cells, all 72 countries usable, no co-missingness pattern to diagnose and no imputation or listwise deletion required. This is by construction — the 72 countries are precisely those with a complete record on all 41 regressors, so *completeness is baked into how the sample was drawn* (the flip side of the selection caveat noted above). Every method below therefore sees the identical 72 countries, which makes their out-of-sample comparison a clean apples-to-apples race.

2.5 Bivariate relationships with growth

We now line up growth against each of the most salient predictors. First the two headline **continuous** determinants, each with an OLS smoother and its raw correlation with growth:

```
par(mfrow = c(1, 2), mar = c(4, 4, 2, 1))
plot(d$GDP60, d$y, pch = 19, col = "steelblue",
     xlab = "GDP60 (log initial income, 1960)",
     ylab = "annual growth 1960-1992")
abline(lm(y ~ GDP60, data = d), col = "firebrick", lwd = 2)
title(sprintf("Convergence (r = %.2f)", cor(d$GDP60, d$y)),
     line = 0.6, cex.main = 0.95)
plot(d$EquipInv, d$y, pch = 19, col = "steelblue",
     xlab = "EquipInv (equipment investment share)",
     ylab = "annual growth 1960-1992")
abline(lm(y ~ EquipInv, data = d), col = "firebrick", lwd = 2)
title(sprintf("Investment (r = %.2f)", cor(d$EquipInv, d$y)),
     line = 0.6, cex.main = 0.95)
```

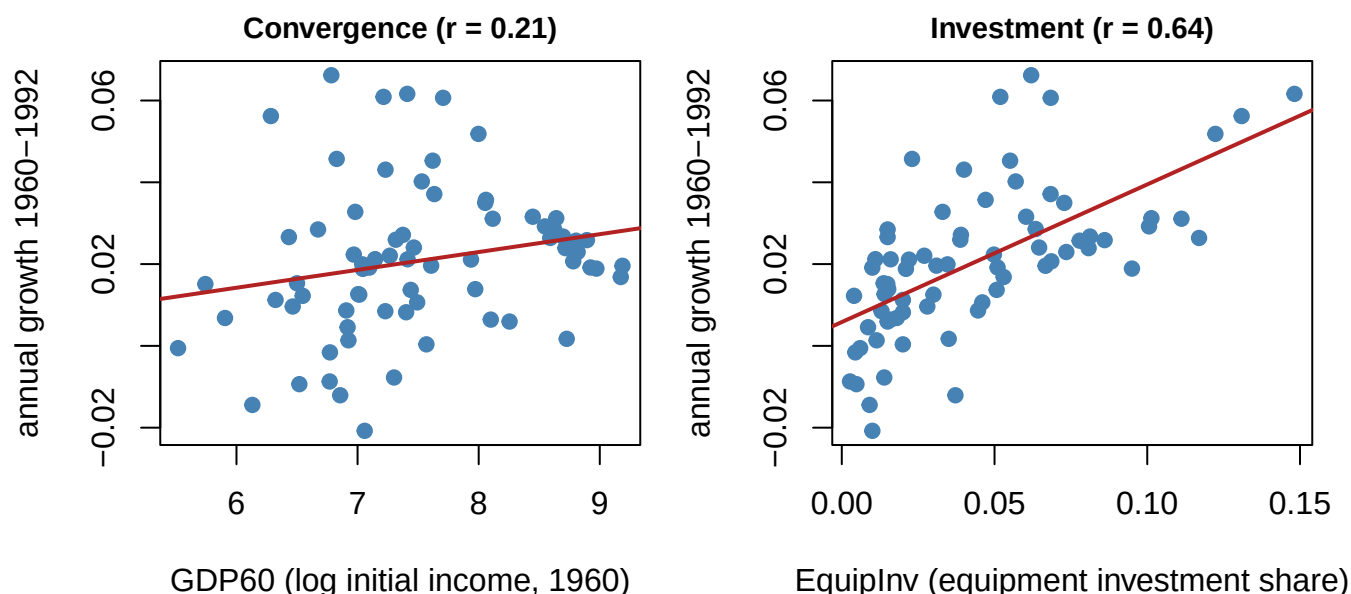


Figure 4: Growth vs the two headline continuous determinants, with least-squares smoother and Pearson r . Left: conditional convergence — higher initial income is associated with slower subsequent growth. Right: higher equipment investment is associated with faster growth.

Then the strongest **categorical** contrast — the Sub-Saharan growth deficit — as a boxplot with a difference-in-means:

```
boxplot(y ~ SubSahara, data = d, col = c("grey85", "firebrick"),
        names = c("Rest of world", "Sub-Saharan Africa"),
        ylab = "annual growth 1960-1992", xlab = "")
gap <- mean(d$y[d$SubSahara == 0]) - mean(d$y[d$SubSahara == 1])
title(sprintf("Mean gap = %.1f pct pts / yr", 100 * gap),
       line = 0.5, cex.main = 0.95)
```

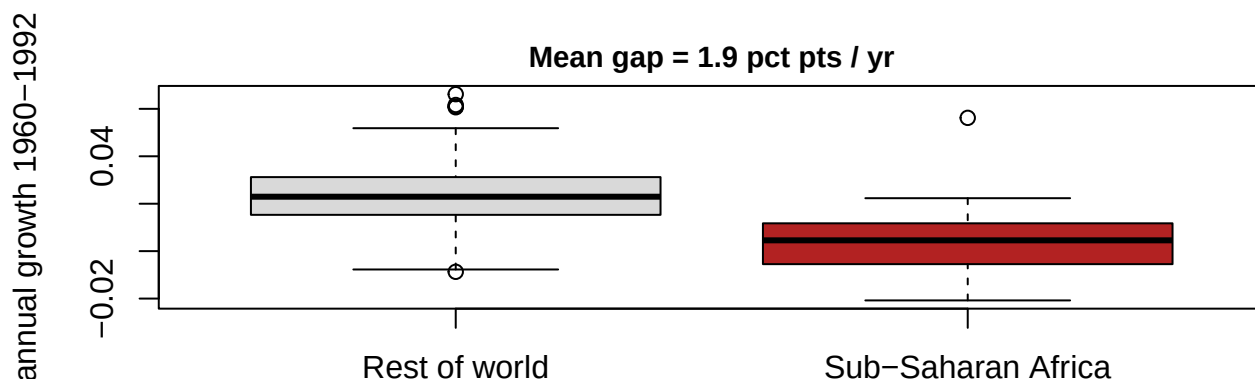


Figure 5: Growth by region. Sub-Saharan African economies grew markedly slower than the rest of the sample over 1960–1992.

To summarize *every* predictor’s marginal association compactly, we rank all 41 by the absolute correlation of the outcome with the predictor (for the dummies this equals a standardized difference in means), and show the strongest links:

```
cors <- sapply(colnames(d)[-1], function(v) cor(d[[v]], d$y))
marg <- data.frame(variable = names(cors),
                   cor_with_y = round(cors, 3),
                   abs_cor = round(abs(cors), 3),
                   row.names = NULL)
marg <- marg[order(-marg$abs_cor), ]
knitr::kable(head(marg, 12), row.names = FALSE,
                 caption = "Twelve predictors most strongly correlated (in absolute value) with growth.
                 ↪ Sign shown; these are the raw marginal associations, before adjusting for the heavy
                 ↪ collinearity documented next.")
```

Table 5: Twelve predictors most strongly correlated (in absolute value) with growth. Sign shown; these are the raw marginal associations, before adjusting for the heavy collinearity documented next.

variable	cor_with_y	abs_cor
EquipInv	0.636	0.636
YrsOpen	0.603	0.603
Confucian	0.512	0.512
PrExports	-0.509	0.509
RuleofLaw	0.503	0.503
LifeExp	0.491	0.491
Buddha	0.450	0.450

variable	cor_with_y	abs_cor
PrScEnroll	0.449	0.449
NequipInv	0.442	0.442
SubSahara	-0.434	0.434
EcoOrg	0.370	0.370
PolRights	-0.366	0.366

The leaders — initial income (negative: convergence), equipment investment, life expectancy, primary schooling, the Confucian share and the Sub-Saharan dummy — are exactly the determinants FLS’s BMA later ranks at the top. But these are *marginal* associations; the next subsection shows why we cannot simply read them as effects.

2.6 Multivariate structure and collinearity

With many predictors describing overlapping facets of “development”, collinearity is the central statistical hazard: if income, health, schooling and investment all rise together, no single regression can cleanly attribute growth to one of them. A correlation heatmap over the salient continuous predictors makes the entanglement visible (a 41x41 heatmap would be an unreadable postage stamp):

```
key_num <- c("GDP60", "LifeExp", "EquipInv", "NequipInv", "PrScEnroll",
             "HighEnroll", "RuleofLaw", "YrsOpen", "Age", "Abslat")
C <- cor(d[, key_num])
cm <- as.data.frame(as.table(C)); names(cm) <- c("v1", "v2", "r")
ggplot(cm, aes(v1, v2, fill = r)) +
  geom_tile(colour = "white") +
  geom_text(aes(label = sprintf("%.2f", r)), size = 2.7) +
  scale_fill_gradient2(low = "firebrick", mid = "white",
                      high = "steelblue", midpoint = 0,
                      limits = c(-1, 1)) +
  labs(x = NULL, y = NULL, fill = "r") +
  theme_minimal(base_size = 9) +
  theme(axis.text.x = element_text(angle = 45, hjust = 1))
```

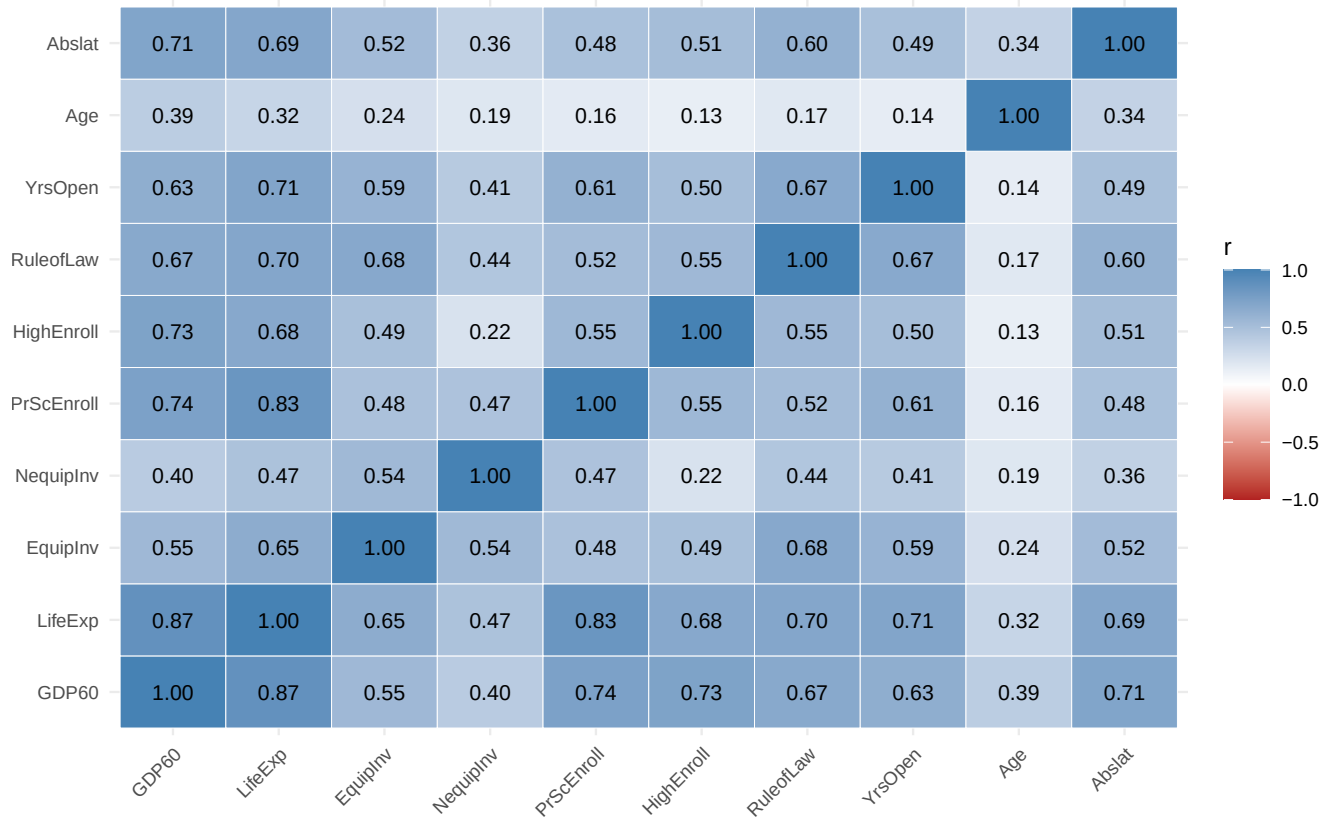


Figure 6: Correlation heatmap among the salient continuous predictors. Initial income, life expectancy, schooling and equipment investment form a strongly positively correlated block — the collinearity that makes single-regression inference unstable and motivates shrinkage/selection.

To quantify what “strong” means, list every predictor pair (across ALL 41 continuous+binary regressors) with $|r| > 0.7$:

```
Cfull <- cor(d[, -1])
Cfull[upper.tri(Cfull, diag = TRUE)] <- NA
hi <- which(abs(Cfull) > 0.7, arr.ind = TRUE)
if (nrow(hi) == 0) {
  cat("No predictor pair exceeds  $|r| = 0.7$ .\n")
} else {
  hipairs <- data.frame(
    var1 = rownames(Cfull)[hi[, 1]],
    var2 = colnames(Cfull)[hi[, 2]],
    r = round(Cfull[hi], 3)
  )
  hipairs <- hipairs[order(-abs(hipairs$r)), ]
  knitr::kable(hipairs, row.names = FALSE,
    caption = "All predictor pairs with  $|r| > 0.7$  across the full 41-predictor set.")
}
```

Table 6: All predictor pairs with $|r| > 0.7$ across the full 41-predictor set.

var1	var2	r
CivLib	PolRights	0.961
GDP60	LifeExp	0.869
LatAmerica	Spanish	0.862
LabForce	Hindu	0.846
LifeExp	PrScEnroll	0.830
CivLib	GDP60	-0.822
Popg	Abslat	-0.808
Popg	LifeExp	-0.807
CivLib	LifeExp	-0.792
PolRights	GDP60	-0.777
PolRights	LifeExp	-0.770
Popg	GDP60	-0.740
GDP60	PrScEnroll	0.737
HighEnroll	GDP60	0.726
GDP60	Abslat	0.709
YrsOpen	LifeExp	0.706

Life expectancy, initial income, schooling and equipment investment move together (pairwise r up to ≈ 0.8): richer, healthier, better-schooled economies cluster. Ordinary least squares cannot cleanly attribute growth to any one of them — precisely the identification problem FLS confront with BMA and we revisit with lasso and best-subset. As a final compact view of the joint structure among the four headline determinants, a `GGally::ggpairs` panel shows their pairwise scatters, marginal densities and correlations together:

```
suppressMessages(library(GGally))
ggpairs(d[, c("GDP60", "LifeExp", "PrScEnroll", "EquipInv")],
  lower = list(continuous = wrap("points", alpha = 0.5,
    size = 0.7, colour = "steelblue"))) +
  theme_minimal(base_size = 8)
```

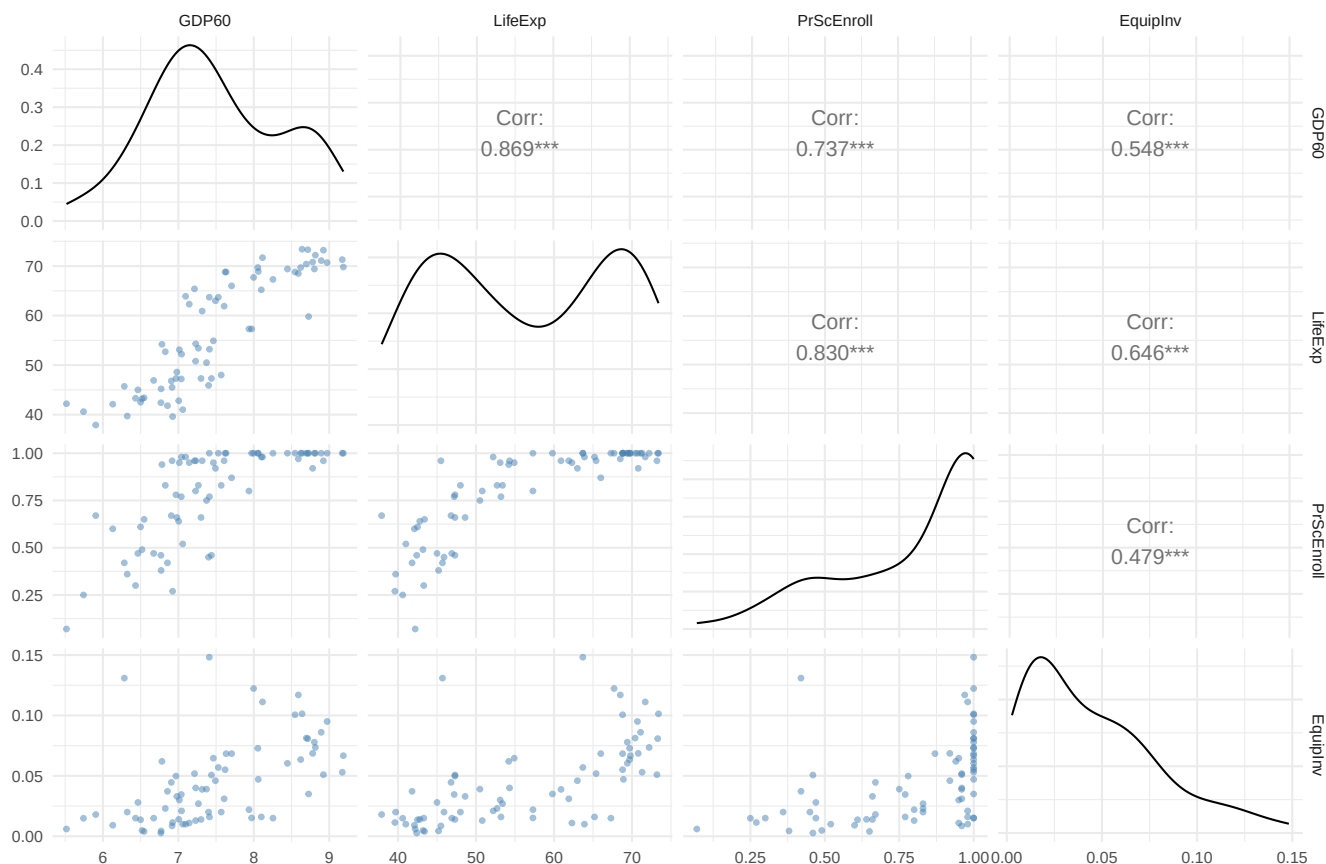


Figure 7: Pairwise structure of the four headline determinants (GGally::ggpairs): scatterplots below the diagonal, densities on it, correlations above. The uniformly positive off-diagonal correlations are the collinearity that shrinkage and selection are built to handle.

What the descriptives foreshadow. Growth is a well-behaved, near-symmetric continuous outcome with modest spread (≈ 1.8 percentage points), no missingness, and no transformation needed. Its strongest raw associations are the classic convergence signal (negative slope on initial income GDP60), a positive equipment-investment gradient, and a large Sub-Saharan growth deficit — exactly the determinants FLS’s BMA ranks at the top. But those salient predictors are themselves tightly intercorrelated (several pairs with $|r| > 0.7$), and their scales span orders of magnitude. That combination — 41 correlated predictors on wildly different scales over just 72 countries — is the whole reason the reproduction below turns to model averaging, why standardization is mandatory, and why the regularization and best-subset extensions earn their keep out-of-sample.

3 Reproduction gate 1 — the data are the published data

FLS print descriptive statistics for every variable. Matching them to printed precision proves we hold the exact published dataset.

```
pubstats <- data.frame(
  var      = c("y", "PrScEnroll", "LifeExp", "GDP60", "Muslim", "RuleofLaw", "EquipInv"),
  pub_mean = c(0.02073, 0.7953, 56.58, 7.492, 0.1475, 0.5509, 0.04429),
  pub_std  = c(0.01813, 0.2440, 11.37, 0.8785, 0.2925, 0.3329, 0.03426))
pubstats$our_mean <- round(sapply(pubstats$var, function(v) mean(d[[v]])), 5)
# FLS report the population s.d. (divide by n); our sample sd divides by n-1
pubstats$our_std  <- round(sapply(pubstats$var,
```

```
function(v) sd(d[[v]]) * sqrt((n-1)/n)), 4)
knitr::kable(pubstats, caption = "Data provenance: our data vs FLS (2001) printed
↪ descriptive statistics.")
```

Table 7: Data provenance: our data vs FLS (2001) printed descriptive statistics.

var	pub_mean	pub_std	our_mean	our_std
y	0.02073	0.01813	0.02073	0.0181
PrScEnroll	0.79530	0.24400	0.79528	0.2440
LifeExp	56.58000	11.37000	56.58056	11.3681
GDP60	7.49200	0.87850	7.49167	0.8785
Muslim	0.14750	0.29250	0.14750	0.2925
RuleofLaw	0.55090	0.33290	0.55093	0.3329
EquipInv	0.04429	0.03426	0.04429	0.0343

Means and standard deviations match the published figures to printed precision.

4 Reproduce the published main result: BMA posterior inclusion probabilities

FLS's Table I ranks the 41 regressors by posterior inclusion probability under their **benchmark g -prior** ($g = 1/\max(n, k^2) = 1/k^2$ here) and a uniform prior over model size. We reproduce it with `BMS::bms()` using an MC³ sampler (full enumeration of 2^{41} models is infeasible).

```
mfls <- bms(d, burn = 1e5, iter = 1e6, g = "BRIC", mprior = "uniform",
            nmodel = 10000, mcmc = "bd", user.int = FALSE)
```

```
cat("Sampler convergence (corr of analytic vs MCMC model probs):",
    round(mfls$info$corr.pmp, 3), "\n")
```

```
## Sampler convergence (corr of analytic vs MCMC model probs): 0.989
```

```
pip_bma <- coef(mfls, exact = TRUE)[, "PIP"] # posterior inclusion probs
```

The convergence correlation (≈ 0.99) confirms the chain has identified the high-probability region. Now compare our reproduced PIPs to the numbers printed in FLS Table I (p. 9):

```
pub <- data.frame(
  var = c("GDP60", "Confucian", "LifeExp", "EquipInv", "SubSahara", "Muslim",
          "RuleofLaw", "YrsOpen", "EcoOrg", "Protestants", "NequipInv", "Mining"),
  published_PIP = c(1.000, 0.995, 0.946, 0.942, 0.757, 0.656,
                   0.516, 0.502, 0.471, 0.461, 0.441, 0.431))
pub$reproduced_PIP <- round(pip_bma[pub$var], 3)
pub$abs_diff <- round(abs(pub$published_PIP - pub$reproduced_PIP), 3)
knitr::kable(pub, caption = "Reproduction of FLS (2001) Table I: the 12 highest
↪ posterior-inclusion-probability growth determinants. Published vs reproduced.")
```

Table 8: Reproduction of FLS (2001) Table I: the 12 highest posterior-inclusion-probability growth determinants. Published vs reproduced.

var	published_PIP	reproduced_PIP	abs_diff
GDP60	1.000	1.000	0.000
Confucian	0.995	0.998	0.003
LifeExp	0.946	0.951	0.005
EquipInv	0.942	0.950	0.008
SubSahara	0.757	0.768	0.011
Muslim	0.656	0.668	0.012
RuleofLaw	0.516	0.534	0.018
YrsOpen	0.502	0.495	0.007
EcoOrg	0.471	0.483	0.012
Protestants	0.461	0.469	0.008
NequipInv	0.441	0.434	0.007
Mining	0.431	0.428	0.003

```
cat("Top-12 mean absolute PIP difference:",
    round(mean(pub$abs_diff), 4), "\n")
```

```
## Top-12 mean absolute PIP difference: 0.0078
```

The reproduced posterior inclusion probabilities match the published values to within Monte-Carlo error (mean absolute difference ≈ 0.01). **The gate is passed:** the same variables emerge as important, in the same order, with the same magnitudes. FLS’s substantive story — initial GDP (conditional convergence), equipment investment, life expectancy, a Confucian dummy, and Sub-Saharan Africa dominate; most of the other 33 regressors are dispensable — is reproduced.

5 The OLS that motivates everything

Before regularizing, look at why you *cannot* just run one big OLS on all 41 predictors with $n = 72$.

```
ols <- lm(y ~ ., data = d)
s <- summary(ols)
data.frame(R2 = round(s$r.squared,3), adjR2 = round(s$adj.r.squared,3),
            residual_df = ols$df.residual, n = n, params = length(coef(ols)))
```

```
##      R2 adjR2 residual_df  n params
## 1 0.96 0.905          30 72     42
```

The full model spends 42 parameters on 72 observations, leaving only 30 residual degrees of freedom. In-sample $R^2 = 0.96$ looks spectacular — and is almost entirely overfitting, as the out-of-sample comparison below will show. This is the canonical setting where **regularization and selection** are not optional niceties but the difference between a useful model and a useless one.

6 Standardization — why and how

Penalized methods shrink coefficients toward zero, so the *scale* of each predictor matters: a coefficient on `LifeExp` (range roughly 40–75 years) and one on a 0/1 religion dummy are penalized on wildly different footings unless we put all predictors on a common scale. `glmnet` standardizes internally (`standardize = TRUE`) — fits on z -scored predictors, then reports coefficients back on the original scale. Here is the effect explicitly:

```
Xs <- scale(X) # mean 0, sd 1
round(rbind(`orig sd` = apply(X, 2, sd)[1:6],
           `scaled sd` = apply(Xs, 2, sd)[1:6]), 3)
```

```
##          Abslat Spanish French Brit WarDummy LatAmerica
## orig sd   17.25   0.419  0.333 0.47   0.494   0.451
## scaled sd   1.00   1.000  1.000 1.00   1.000   1.000
```

7 Ridge, lasso and elastic net via glmnet

glmnet fits the elastic-net family, minimizing $\frac{1}{2n}\|y - X\beta\|^2 + \lambda[\alpha\|\beta\|_1 + \frac{1-\alpha}{2}\|\beta\|_2^2]$: $\alpha = 1$ is **lasso** (sparse; sets coefficients exactly to zero), $\alpha = 0$ is **ridge** (shrinks but keeps all), and intermediate α is **elastic net**.

```
library(glmnet)
fit_ridge <- glmnet(X, y, alpha = 0, standardize = TRUE)
fit_lasso <- glmnet(X, y, alpha = 1, standardize = TRUE)
fit_enet <- glmnet(X, y, alpha = 0.5, standardize = TRUE)
```

7.1 Coefficient paths

As λ falls (right to left) predictors enter the model. Lasso admits them one at a time and keeps most at exactly zero; ridge moves them all together.

```
par(mfrow = c(1, 2), mar = c(4, 4, 3, 1))
plot(fit_lasso, xvar = "lambda"); title("Lasso path", line = 2.2)
plot(fit_ridge, xvar = "lambda"); title("Ridge path", line = 2.2)
```

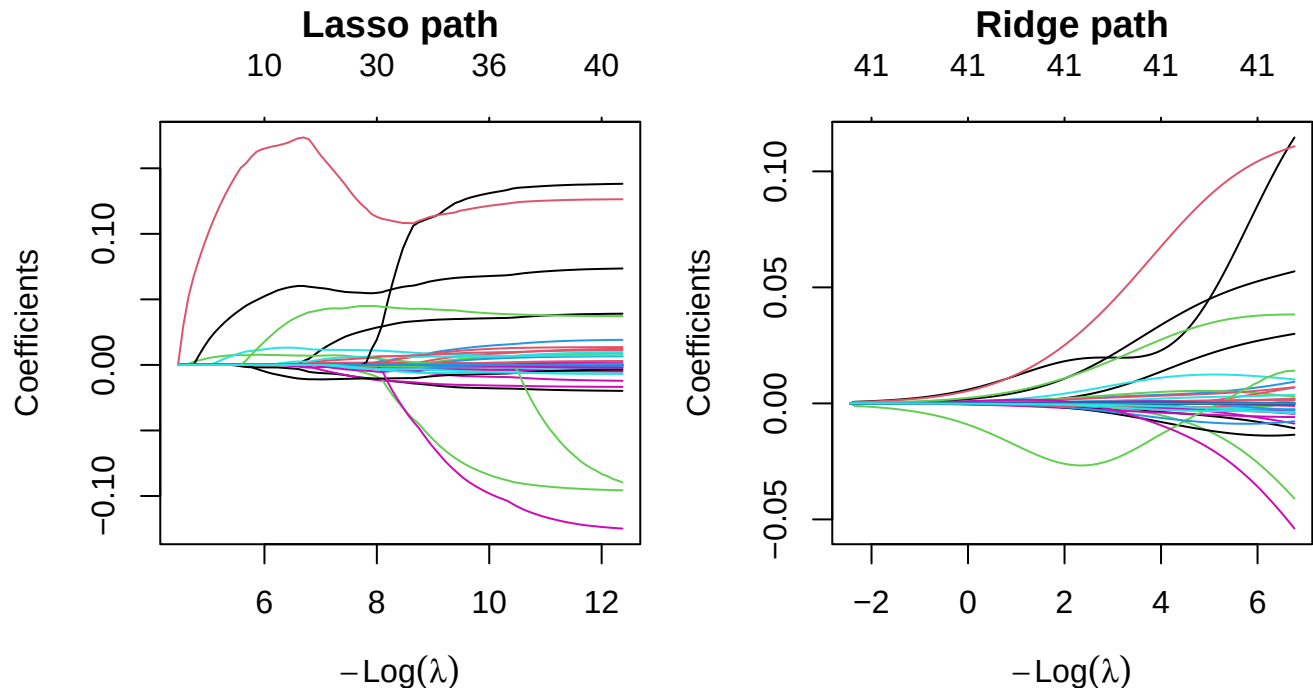


Figure 8: Coefficient paths. Left: lasso ($\alpha = 1$) — sparse, coefficients enter one at a time. Right: ridge ($\alpha = 0$) — all coefficients shrink together, none exactly zero.

7.2 Cross-validation to choose λ (`lambda.min` and `lambda.1se`)

```
set.seed(1)
cv_lasso <- cv.glmnet(X, y, alpha = 1, nfolds = 10, standardize = TRUE)
cv_ridge <- cv.glmnet(X, y, alpha = 0, nfolds = 10, standardize = TRUE)
cv_enet <- cv.glmnet(X, y, alpha = 0.5, nfolds = 10, standardize = TRUE)
par(mfrow = c(1, 2), mar = c(4, 4, 3, 1))
plot(cv_lasso); title("Lasso CV", line = 2.4)
plot(cv_enet); title("Elastic-net CV", line = 2.4)
```

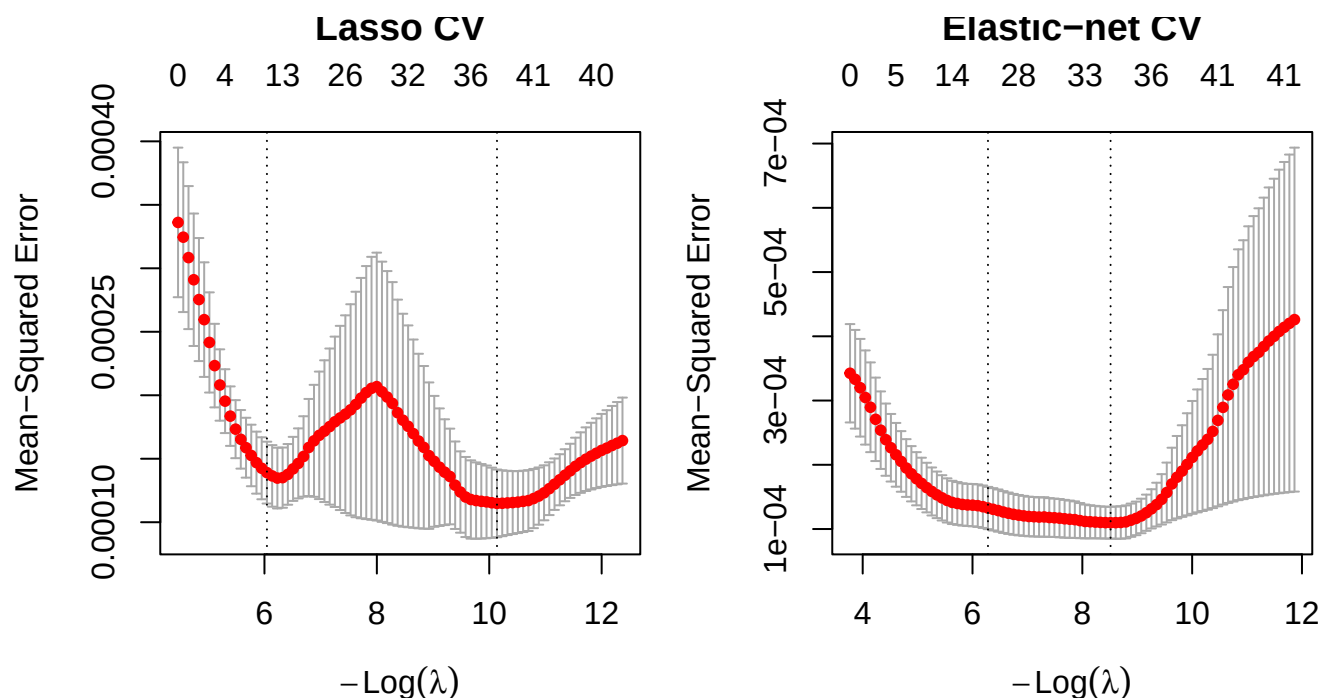


Figure 9: 10-fold CV curves. Dotted lines mark `lambda.min` (loss-minimizing) and `lambda.1se` (sparsest model within 1 s.e.).

```
sel <- function(cvfit, s) {
  b <- coef(cvfit, s = s); nm <- rownames(b)[which(b != 0)]
  setdiff(nm, "(Intercept)")
}
lasso_min <- sel(cv_lasso, "lambda.min")
lasso_1se <- sel(cv_lasso, "lambda.1se")
data.frame(rule = c("lambda.min", "lambda.1se"),
            n_kept = c(length(lasso_min), length(lasso_1se)),
            lambda = signif(c(cv_lasso$lambda.min, cv_lasso$lambda.1se), 3))

##           rule n_kept  lambda
## 1 lambda.min      36 3.96e-05
## 2 lambda.1se     10 2.37e-03
```

Interpreting shrinkage: at `lambda.min` the lasso keeps 36 predictors, while the more conservative `lambda.1se` rule — the sparsest model whose CV error is within one standard error of the minimum — keeps only 10:

```
lasso_1se
```

```
## [1] "SubSahara" "EcoOrg" "YrsOpen" "Buddha" "Confucian"
↪ "Protestants"
## [7] "RFEXDist" "EquipInv" "NequipInv" "stdBMP"
```

7.3 Feature importance from standardized coefficients

With predictors standardized, the magnitude of each lasso coefficient is directly comparable across variables — an importance ranking. (glmnet reports on the original scale, so we multiply by each predictor's s.d. to standardize.)

```
sdx <- apply(X, 2, sd)
bise <- as.numeric(coef(cv_lasso, s = "lambda.1se"))[-1]
imp <- data.frame(var = colnames(X), std_coef = bise * sdx)
imp <- imp[imp$std_coef != 0, ]
imp <- imp[order(imp$std_coef), ]
par(mar = c(4, 7, 2, 1))
barplot(imp$std_coef, names.arg = imp$var, horiz = TRUE, las = 1,
        col = ifelse(imp$std_coef > 0, "steelblue", "firebrick"),
        xlab = "standardized coefficient (effect on annual growth)")
abline(v = 0)
```

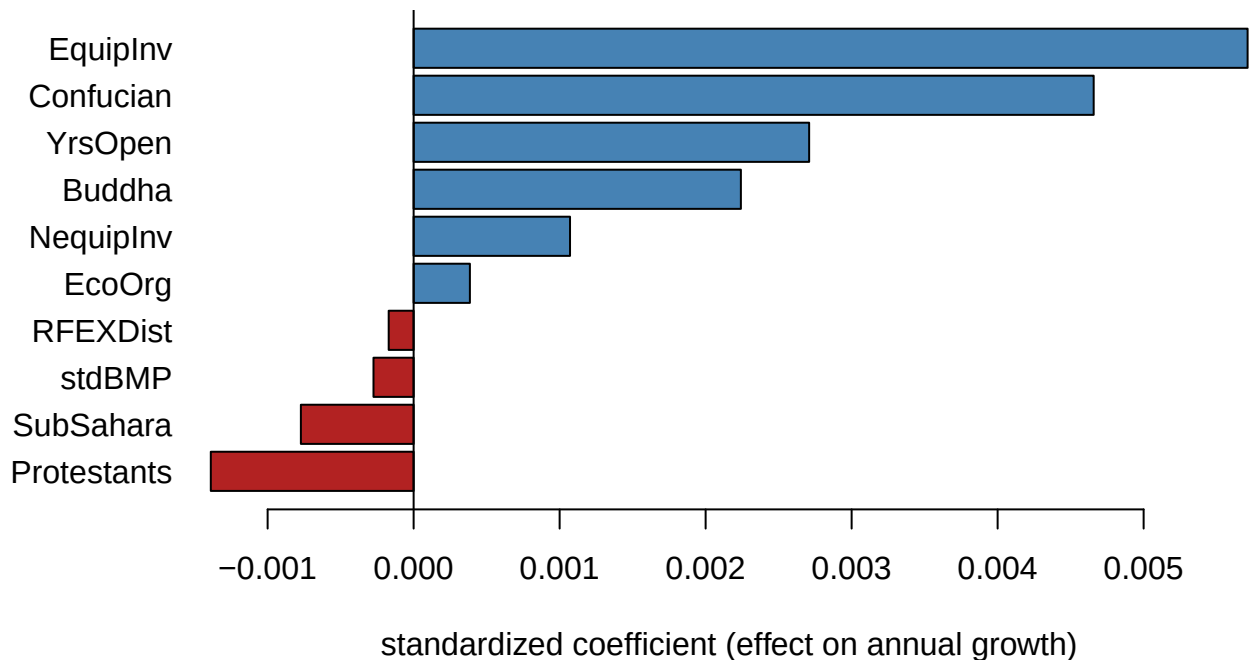


Figure 10: Standardized lasso (lambda.1se) coefficients: signed importance of the retained growth determinants.

8 Best-subset selection with abess, contrasted with lasso

Lasso selects by convex ℓ_1 shrinkage; **best-subset** selection instead searches directly for the size- s subset of predictors giving the best fit. Exact best-subset is NP-hard, but the **abess** algorithm (adaptive best-subset) solves it efficiently and picks the support size by an information criterion.

```
library(abess)
keepX <- apply(X, 2, function(z) stats::sd(z) > 0) # guard against any constant
↪ column
```

```

ab      <- abess(X[, keepX, drop = FALSE], y, family = "gaussian")  # support size
↳ chosen by GIC
ab_best <- extract(ab)
abess_support <- ab_best$support.vars
data.frame(method = "abess (best subset)",
            support_size = length(abess_support))

##                method support_size
## 1 abess (best subset)             13

abess_support

## [1] "SubSahara"  "LifeExp"    "GDP60"    "Mining"    "EcoOrg"    "Buddha"
## [7] "Confucian"    "Hindu"     "Muslim"   "Protestants" "RuleofLaw" "EquipInv"
## [13] "NequipInv"

```

How the three selectors compare. Lay each method's kept set beside the BMA "ground truth" (variables with reproduced PIP > 0.4):

```

bma_important <- names(sort(pip_bma, decreasing = TRUE))[pip_bma[
  order(pip_bma, decreasing = TRUE)] > 0.4]
allv <- colnames(X)
tab <- data.frame(
  variable = allv,
  BMA_PIP  = round(pip_bma[allv], 2),
  BMA_top  = ifelse(allv %in% bma_important, "*", ""),
  lasso_1se = ifelse(allv %in% lasso_1se, "*", ""),
  abess     = ifelse(allv %in% abess_support, "*", ""))
tab <- tab[order(-tab$BMA_PIP), ]
knitr::kable(head(tab, 16), row.names = FALSE,
  caption = "Which predictors each method keeps (top 16 by BMA PIP). A '*' marks
↳ inclusion. abess best-subset closely tracks the BMA important set; lasso-1se is
↳ sparser and drops some high-PIP variables it cannot separate from correlated
↳ rivals.")

```

Table 9: Which predictors each method keeps (top 16 by BMA PIP). A '*' marks inclusion. abess best-subset closely tracks the BMA important set; lasso-1se is sparser and drops some high-PIP variables it cannot separate from correlated rivals.

variable	BMA_PIP	BMA_top	lasso_1se	abess
GDP60	1.00	*		*
Confucian	1.00	*	*	*
LifeExp	0.95	*		*
EquipInv	0.95	*	*	*
SubSahara	0.77	*	*	*
Muslim	0.67	*		*
RuleofLaw	0.53	*		*
YrsOpen	0.50	*	*	
EcoOrg	0.48	*	*	*
Protestants	0.47	*	*	*
Mining	0.43	*		*
NequipInv	0.43	*	*	*
LatAmerica	0.17			
PrScEnroll	0.17			

variable	BMA_PIP	BMA_top	lasso_1se	abess
Buddha	0.15		*	*
BLMktPm	0.14			

The contrast is the lesson: **abess best-subset recovers almost exactly the FLS BMA important set** — initial GDP, Confucian, life expectancy, equipment investment, Sub-Saharan Africa, Muslim, rule of law — whereas **lasso at lambda.1se is sparser** and, because it shrinks correlated predictors together, substitutes some proxies and drops a few high-PIP variables. Neither is “wrong”: lasso optimizes prediction under shrinkage; best-subset optimizes fit at a fixed sparsity; BMA hedges over all models.

9 Hyperparameter tuning: λ and α together

Elastic net has two knobs. We already tune λ by CV; now tune α over a grid and read off the CV-optimal combination.

```
alphas <- seq(0, 1, by = 0.1)
set.seed(7)
foldid <- sample(rep(1:10, length.out = n)) # common folds => fair alpha comparison
cvm <- sapply(alphas, function(a) {
  min(cv.glmnet(X, y, alpha = a, foldid = foldid, standardize = TRUE)$cvm)
})
best_alpha <- alphas[which.min(cvm)]
plot(alphas, cvm, type = "b", pch = 19, col = "steelblue",
     xlab = expression(alpha ~ "(0 = ridge, 1 = lasso)"),
     ylab = "min 10-fold CV MSE")
abline(v = best_alpha, lty = 2)
```

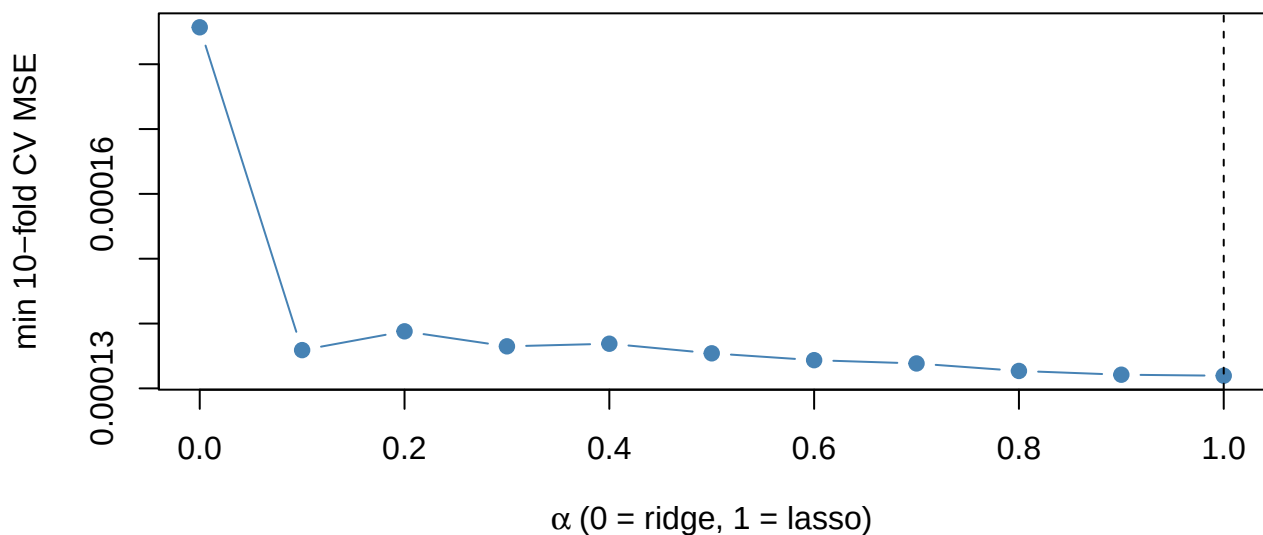


Figure 11: Tuning the elastic-net mixing parameter α . Each point is the minimum 10-fold CV MSE at that α ; lower is better.

```
cat("CV-optimal alpha:", best_alpha, "\n")
```

```
## CV-optimal alpha: 1
```

10 Out-of-sample comparison: does regularization actually help?

The honest test. We repeat a 70/30 train–test split 100 times; on each split we fit every method on the training rows (choosing λ by inner CV) and score RMSE on the held-out rows. We include the full OLS and a mean-only baseline.

```
rmse <- function(a, b) sqrt(mean((a - b)^2))
R <- 100
methods <- c("OLS (full)", "Ridge", "Lasso", "Elastic net", "abess", "Mean baseline")
res <- matrix(NA, R, length(methods), dimnames = list(NULL, methods))
set.seed(2024)
for (r in 1:R) {
  te <- sample(n, size = round(0.30 * n)); tr <- setdiff(1:n, te)
  Xtr <- X[tr,]; Xte <- X[te,]; ytr <- y[tr]; yte <- y[te]
  ols_r <- lm(y ~ ., data = data.frame(y = ytr, Xtr))
  res[r, "OLS (full)"] <- rmse(yte, predict(ols_r, newdata = data.frame(Xte)))
  for (a in c(0, 1, 0.5)) {
    cv <- cv.glmnet(Xtr, ytr, alpha = a, nfolds = 5, standardize = TRUE)
    pr <- as.numeric(predict(cv, newx = Xte, s = "lambda.min"))
    nm <- c("Ridge", "Lasso", "Elastic net")[match(a, c(0, 1, 0.5))]
    res[r, nm] <- rmse(yte, pr)
  }
  keep <- apply(Xtr, 2, function(z) stats::sd(z) > 0) # a rare 0/1 dummy can be constant
  ↪ in a fold
  ab_r <- abess(Xtr[, keep, drop = FALSE], ytr, family = "gaussian")
  res[r, "abess"] <- rmse(yte, as.numeric(predict(ab_r, newx = Xte[, keep, drop =
  ↪ FALSE])))
  res[r, "Mean baseline"] <- rmse(yte, mean(ytr))
}
oos <- data.frame(method = methods,
                  mean_RMSE = round(colMeans(res), 5),
                  se_RMSE = round(apply(res, 2, sd) / sqrt(R), 5))
oos <- oos[order(oos$mean_RMSE), ]
knitr::kable(oos, row.names = FALSE,
  caption = "Out-of-sample RMSE over 100 repeated 70/30 splits (smaller is better). y has
  ↪ s.d. 0.018.")
```

Table 10: Out-of-sample RMSE over 100 repeated 70/30 splits (smaller is better). y has s.d. 0.018.

method	mean_RMSE	se_RMSE
Elastic net	0.01406	0.00069
Lasso	0.01435	0.00074
Ridge	0.01534	0.00033
abess	0.01677	0.00106
Mean baseline	0.01804	0.00027
OLS (full)	0.04599	0.00624

```
ord <- oos$method
boxplot(res[, ord], las = 2, col = "grey85", ylab = "held-out RMSE",
  main = "Out-of-sample prediction error by method")
abline(h = sd(y), lty = 3)
```

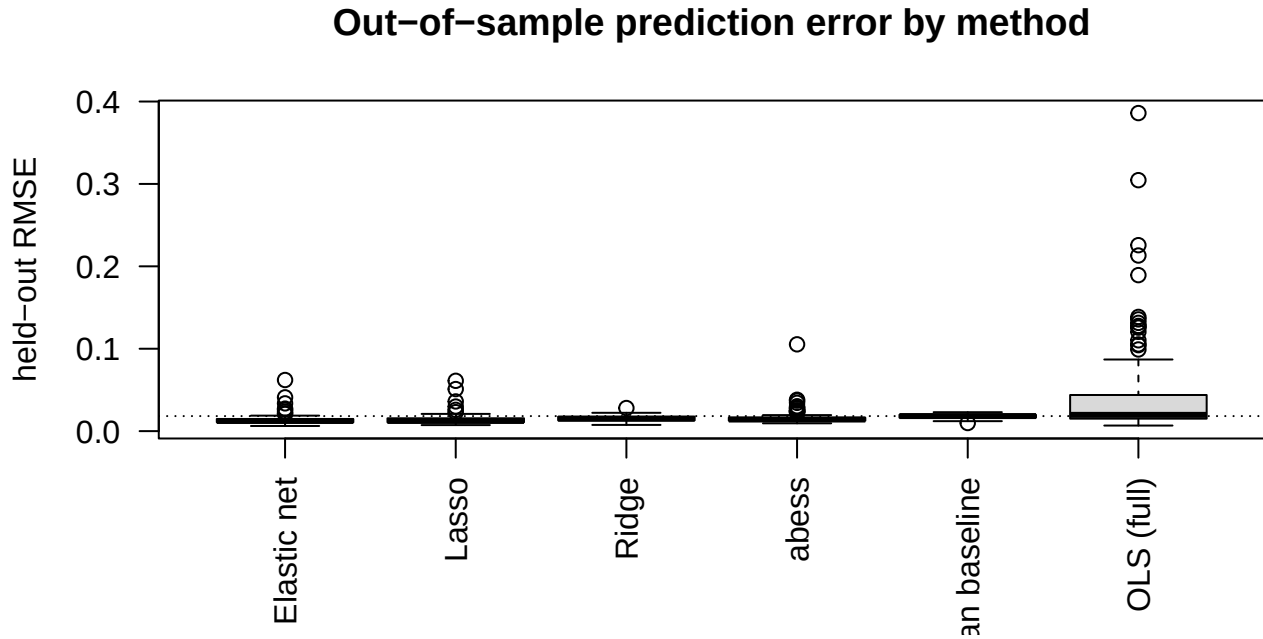


Figure 12: Distribution of held-out RMSE across 100 splits. The full OLS is off the useful scale — it overfits so badly it loses to predicting the mean.

Reading the result. The full OLS is *worse than predicting the training mean* — its in-sample $R^2 = 0.96$ was a mirage. Lasso and elastic net predict best, with ridge and abess close behind; every regularized/selected model beats both OLS and the naive baseline. With 41 correlated predictors and 72 countries, **shrinkage and selection are what make the growth regression usable out-of-sample.**

11 Takeaway

Fernández, Ley & Steel (2001) confronted 41 correlated growth determinants and 72 countries with Bayesian model averaging; we reproduced their headline posterior-inclusion ranking to Monte-Carlo precision (initial GDP, equipment investment, life expectancy, Confucian share, Sub-Saharan Africa, Muslim, rule of law). The modern regularization toolkit tells the same substantive story from a predictive angle: the naive full OLS overfits catastrophically (worse than a mean baseline out-of-sample), while lasso and elastic net predict best, and **best-subset (abess) selection independently recovers almost exactly the BMA important set.** The teaching point is that lasso's ℓ_1 shrinkage, best-subset search, and Bayesian model averaging are three routes to the same conclusion — that only a handful of these 41 determinants carry robust, transferable signal — and that with p large relative to n , choosing among them is not a refinement of OLS but a prerequisite for it.